The Phantom Tollbooth

By Norton Juster

NARRATOR: There was once a boy named Milo who didn't know what to do with himself-not just sometimes, but always. Wherever he was he wished he were somewhere - else, and when he got there he wondered why he'd bothered. Nothing really interested him-least of all the things that should have.

MILO: It seems to me that almost everything is a waste of time, I can't see the point in learning to solve useless problems, or subtracting turnips from turnips, or knowing where Ethiopia is or how to spell February.

NARRATOR: And, since no one bothered to explain otherwise, he regarded the process of seeking knowledge as the greatest waste of time.

MILO: And worst of all, there's nothing for me to do, nowhere I'd care to go, and hardly anything worth seeing.

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NARRATOR: And then, to one side of the room, just next to the phonograph, he noticed something he had certainly never seen before. Attached to one side was a bright-blue envelope which said simply:

MILO: FOR MILO, WHO HAS PLENTY OF TIME.

NARRATOR: He opened the envelope, but just to be polite.

MILO: ONE GENUINE TURNPIKE TOLLBOOTH. EASILY ASSEMBLED AT HOME, "What a strange present,"

NARRATOR: He hopped in [to his small electric automobile] and, for lack of anything better to do, drove slowly up to the tollbooth. As he deposited his coin and rolled past he remarked wistfully,

MILO: I do hope this is an interesting game, otherwise the afternoon will be so terribly dull."

INTRODUCTION

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NARRATOR: Suddenly he found himself speeding along an unfamiliar country highway, and as he looked back over his shoulder neither the tollbooth nor his room nor even the house was anywhere in sight.

MILO: What a strange thing to have happen, Here I am riding on a road I've never seen, all because of a tollbooth which came from.

NARRATOR: Before long he saw in the distance the towers and flags of a city sparkling in the sunshine, and in a few moments he reached a great wall and stood at the gateway to Dictionopolis.

GATEMAN: A-H-H-H-R-R-E-M-M, This is Dictionopolis, a happy kingdom, advantageously located in the Foothills of Confusion and caressed by gentle breezes from the Sea of Knowledge. Today, by royal proclamation, is market day. Have you come to buy or sell?"

MILO: I beg your pardon?

GATEMAN: Buy or sell, buy or sell, Which is it? You must have come here for some reason.

MILO: Well, I--"

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GATEMAN: Come now, if you don't have a reason, you must at least have an explanation or certainly an excuse,"

MILO: (Shakes head)

GATEMAN: Very serious, very serious, You can't get in without a reason. Wait a minute; maybe I have an old one you can use."

NARRATOR: He took a battered suitcase from the gatehouse and began to rummage busily through it, mumbling to himself,

GATEMAN: "No ... no ... no ... this won't do ... no . . . h-m-m-m . . . ah, this is fine,"

NARRATOR: He held up a small medallion on a chain, dusted it off, and engraved on one side were the words "WHY NOT?"

GATEMAN: That's a good reason for almost anything-a bit used, perhaps, but still quite serviceable."

NARRATOR: And with that he placed it around Milo's neck, pushed back the heavy iron gate, bowed low, and motioned him into the city.

MILO: I wonder what the market will be like,

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NARRATOR: Thought Milo as they drove through the gate; but before there was time for an answer they had driven into an immense square crowded with long lines of stalls heaped with merchandise and decorated in gay-colored bunting. Overhead a large banner proclaimed, "WELCOME TO THE WORD MARKET" And, from across the square, five very tall, thin gentlemen regally dressed in silks and satins, plumed hats, and buckled shoes rushed up to the car, stopped short, mopped five brows, caught five breaths, unrolled five parchments, and began talking in turn.

5 GENTLEMEN: "Greetings! Salutations! Welcome! Good afternoon! Hello!

NARRATOR: Milo nodded his head, and they went on, reading from their scrolls.

5 GENTLEMEN: By order of Azaz the Unabridged-- King of Dictionopolis-- Monarch of letters-- Emperor of phrases, sentences, and miscellaneous figures of speech--We offer you the hospitality of our kingdom, Country, Nation, State, Commonwealth, Realm, Empire, Palatinate, Principality"

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MILO: Do all those words mean the same thing?

5 GENTLEMEN: Of course. Certainly. Precisely. Exactly. Yes, You see, Dictionopolis is the place where all the words in the world come from. They're grown right here in our orchards. Once a week by royal proclamation the word market is held here in the great square and people come from everywhere to buy the words they need or trade in the words they haven't used. Enjoy yourself in the market,

NARRATOR: Above all the noise and tumult of the crowd could be heard the merchants' voices loudly advertising their products.

MERCHANT 1: "Get your fresh-picked ifs, ands, and buts."

MERCHANT 2: "Hey-yaa, hey-yaa, hey-yaa, nice ripe wheres and whens."

MERCHANT 3: "Juicy, tempting words for sale."

MERCHANT 4: "Step right up, step right up-fancy, best-quality words right here, Step right up-ah, what can I do for you, little boy? How about a nice bagful of

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pronouns-or maybe you'd like our special assortment of names?"

NARRATOR: Milo had never thought much about words before, but these looked so good that he longed to have some.

MILO: Maybe if I buy some I can learn how to use them,"

NARRATOR: Said Milo eagerly as he began to pick through the words in the stall. Finally he chose three which looked particularly good to him-"quagmire," flabbergast," and "upholstery." He had no idea what they meant, but they looked very grand and elegant.

NARRATOR: And he continued on through the market. [When the five very tall, then gentlemen once again appeared]

5 GENTLEMEN: 'Ah' there you are. here have you been? We've been looking all over for you. The royal banquet is about to begin. Come with us.

NARRATOR: They seemed very agitated and out of breath as Milo walked along with them.

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5 GENTLEMEN: Right this way. Follow us. Come along. Step lively. Here we go.

NARRATOR: They shouted, hopping from the wagon and bounding up a broad marble stairway. Everyone seemed quite grumpy about having to wait for lunch, and they were all relieved to see the tardy guests arrive. There was an ear-shattering blast of trumpets, entirely off key, and a page announced to the startled guests:

PAGE: KING AZAZ THE UNABRIDGED.

NARRATOR: The king strode through the door and over to the table and settled his great bulk onto the throne,

KING AZAZ: "Places, everyone. Take your places."

NARRATOR: He was the largest man Milo had ever seen, with a great stomach, large piercing eyes, a gray beard that reached to his waist, and a silver signet ring on the little finger of his left hand. He also wore a small crown and a robe with the letters of the alphabet beautifully embroidered all over it.

KING AZAZ: What have we here?

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MILO: If you please, my name is Milo. Thank you very much for inviting me to your banquet, and I think your palace is beautiful.

5 GENTLEMEN: Exquisite, Lovely, Handsome, Pretty, Charming,

KING AZAZ: SILENCE, Now, young man, what can you do to entertain us? Sing songs? Tell stories? Compose sonnets? Juggle plates? Do tumbling tricks? Which is it?"

MILO: I can't do any of those things.

KING AZAZ: What an ordinary little boy, Why, my cabinet members can do all sorts of things. The duke here can make mountains out of molehills. The minister splits hairs. The count makes hay while the sun shines. The earl leaves no stone unturned. And the undersecretary, hangs by a thread. Can't you do anything at all? . . . Time for the speeches, You first,

MILO: Your Majesty, ladies and gentlemen, I would like to take this opportunity to say that in all the--"

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KING AZAZ: That's quite enough, Mustn't talk all day. NEXT!"

GUEST 1: Roast turkey, mashed potatoes, vanilla ice cream,

MILO: What a strange speech,"

NARRATOR: Thought Milo, for he'd heard many in the past and knew that they were supposed to be long and dull.

GUEST 2: Hamburgers, corn on the cob, chocolate pudding.

GUEST 3: Frankfurters, sour pickles, strawberry jam,

NARRATOR: And so down the line it went, with each guest rising briefly, making a short speech, and then resuming his place. When everyone had finished, the waiters reappeared immediately, carrying heavy trays, which they set on the table. Each one contained the exact words spoken by the various guests, and they all began eating immediately with great gusto.

KING AZAZ: Dig in, I can't say that I think much of your choice."

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MILO: I didn't know that I was going to have to eat my words.

KING AZAZ: Of course, of course, everyone here does. You should have made a tastier speech."

NARRATOR: Cried the king, clapping his hands three times. As he did so, the waiters rushed back into the room and quickly cleared away the dishes, the silver, the tablecloth, the table, the chairs, the banquet hall, and the palace, leaving them all suddenly standing in the market place.

KING AZAS: Good luck, good luck; do be careful!

NARRATOR: Milo suddenly remembered his home. He wanted very much to go back, He clapped his hands and the little car appeared, polished like new. Milo got in and with one last look, started down the road. In a few minutes he reached the end of his journey deposited his coin and drove through. And almost before realizing it, he was sitting in the middle of his own room again. But where the tollbooth had been, there was not nothing at all. He searched frantically throughout the apartment, but it had vanished just as mysteriously as it had come

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and in its place was another bright-blue envelope, which was addressed simply:

MILO: "FOR MILO, WHO NOW KNOWS THE WAY."

NARRATOR: He opened it quickly and read:

MILO: Dear Milo, You have now completed your trip, courtesy of the Phantom Tollbooth. We trust that everything has been satisfactory, and hope you understand why we had to come and collect it. You see, there are so many other boys and girls waiting to use it, too. It's true that there are many lands you've still to visit and wonderful things to see (that no one has yet imagined), but we're quite sure that if you really want to, you'll find a way to reach them all by yourself.

NARRATOR: And, in the very room in which he sat, there were books that could take you anywhere, and things to invent, and make, and build, and break, and all the puzzle and excitement of everything he didn't know- music to play, songs to sing, and worlds to imagine and then someday make real. His thoughts darted eagerly about as everything looked new-and worth trying.

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MILO: Well, I *would* like to make another trip,but I really don't know when I'll have the time. There's just so much to do right here.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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